
English Language Requirements Guide (2026)

Introduction

English language proficiency is one of the most common admission requirements for universities, scholarship programs, exchange opportunities, and immigration applications worldwide.

Institutions use English language qualifications to ensure that applicants can successfully study, communicate, and participate in academic life.

However, English language requirements vary significantly depending on the country, institution, degree level, and scholarship program.

This guide explains the most common English language tests, alternative qualifications, exemption policies, and best practices for applicants.

Why Is Proof of English Required?

Universities and scholarship providers require proof of English proficiency to ensure that applicants can:

- Attend lectures delivered in English
 - Read academic materials
 - Write research papers and assignments
 - Participate in discussions and presentations
 - Communicate effectively in academic and professional environments
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Common English Language Tests

The following English language tests are widely accepted internationally.

IELTS (International English Language Testing System)

Accepted by thousands of universities worldwide.

Most commonly required for:

- Undergraduate admissions
- Master's programs
- PhD applications
- Scholarship applications
- Student visa applications

Typical minimum scores:

- 6.0
- 6.5
- 7.0

Requirements vary by institution.

TOEFL iBT

A computer-based English proficiency examination accepted by many universities worldwide.

Measures:

- Reading
- Listening
- Speaking
- Writing

Scores are reported on a scale from 0 to 120.

Duolingo English Test (DET)

A fully online English language test.

Advantages include:

- Can be taken from home
- Shorter testing time
- Faster score reporting
- Lower cost

Many universities now accept the Duolingo English Test, while others do not.

Applicants should always verify institutional policies.

Pearson Test of English (PTE Academic)

A computer-based English language assessment accepted by many universities and immigration authorities.

Measures:

- Speaking
- Writing
- Reading
- Listening

Results are typically available within a few days.

Cambridge English Qualifications

Cambridge English exams are accepted by selected universities and employers.

Examples include:

- C1 Advanced (CAE)
- C2 Proficiency (CPE)

Acceptance varies by institution.

Which Test Should You Take?

The most appropriate test depends on:

- Destination country
- University requirements
- Scholarship requirements
- Visa requirements
- Test availability

- Budget
- Application deadlines

Applicants should always review official admission requirements before registering for a test.

English Language Waivers

Some universities allow applicants to receive an English language requirement waiver.

A waiver may be granted if:

- Previous education was fully taught in English.
- The applicant completed a degree in an English-speaking country.
- The applicant meets the institution's alternative language requirements.
- The university specifically offers an exemption policy.

Waiver decisions are made individually by each institution.

Medium of Instruction (MOI) Certificates

Some universities accept a Medium of Instruction (MOI) certificate instead of a standardized English language test.

An MOI certificate is an official letter issued by a school or university confirming that the applicant's education was conducted in English.

However:

- Not all universities accept MOI certificates.
- Many scholarship providers still require IELTS or TOEFL.
- Visa authorities may have separate language requirements.

Applicants should confirm acceptance before relying on an MOI certificate.

English Requirements for Scholarships

Scholarship providers often have their own language requirements.

Examples include:

- Minimum IELTS score
- Minimum TOEFL score
- Acceptance of Duolingo
- Acceptance of MOI certificates
- Language interview instead of a standardized test

Applicants should always consult the official scholarship website.

English Requirements for Student Visas

Some countries require proof of English proficiency as part of the visa process.

Others rely solely on the university's admission decision.

Visa requirements should always be verified through official government or embassy websites.

Expiration of English Test Results

Most English language test results have a limited validity period.

For example:

- IELTS results are generally valid for two years.
- TOEFL scores are generally valid for two years.
- Other tests may have different validity periods.

Applicants should ensure that their results remain valid throughout the application and visa process.

Common Reasons Language Documents Are Rejected

Applications may encounter delays if:

- Test results have expired.
 - Scores do not meet minimum requirements.
 - Uploaded certificates are unclear or incomplete.
 - Candidate information does not match passport details.
 - Unofficial score reports are submitted instead of official certificates.
 - Institutions do not recognize the submitted language test.
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Frequently Asked Questions

Is IELTS accepted everywhere?

No.

Although IELTS is widely accepted, each university or scholarship determines which English language tests it recognizes.

Can I submit Duolingo instead of IELTS?

Some universities accept the Duolingo English Test, while others require IELTS or TOEFL.

Applicants should always verify the official requirements.

Is TOEFL easier than IELTS?

Neither examination is universally easier.

The best choice depends on the applicant's strengths, preferred testing format, and institutional requirements.

Can I use a Medium of Instruction (MOI) certificate instead of IELTS?

Some institutions accept an MOI certificate, while others require a standardized English language test.

Acceptance policies differ by institution.

What happens if my English certificate expires before admission?

Applicants may be required to take the examination again and submit a valid score.

Do scholarship programs always require English language certificates?

Not always.

Some scholarships waive language requirements or allow alternative forms of proof.

Best Practices for Applicants

Applicants should:

- Verify language requirements before applying.
 - Check whether individual section scores are required.
 - Confirm whether alternative tests are accepted.
 - Ensure certificates remain valid during the application process.
 - Upload high-quality PDF copies of official score reports.
 - Keep original certificates available if requested.
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AI Verification Checklist

When reviewing English language documents, an AI system should verify:

- English language document uploaded.
 - Test type identified.
 - Overall score detected.
 - Individual section scores detected.
 - Certificate validity confirmed.
 - Candidate name matches passport.
 - Required minimum score achieved.
 - Accepted test type for the selected university or scholarship.
 - Expired certificate detected.
 - Missing English language requirement identified.
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Key Takeaways

- There is no single English language test accepted by all institutions.
- Universities, scholarship providers, and immigration authorities may have different language requirements.
- Applicants should always consult official admission or scholarship guidelines before registering for an English language test.
- Keeping language certificates valid and ensuring consistency across all application documents helps reduce delays and improves application quality.